A Brand of Her Own

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Masaba launched her own label, House of Masaba, in 2009, at age 19. In 2022 came her beauty and wellness brand, Lovechild by Masaba. This year, she was India's only representative on the international panel at the RLC Fashion Summit in Milan

A biracial child, born of celebrity parents, and raised in an unconventional family unit, Masaba Gupta challenges pretty much every assumption of normalcy. "I don't think people who are privileged should speak about privilege as a challenge. Pressure is a privilege, and I've always seen it that way."

Despite inheriting a life that wrote itself more like a soap opera than a fairy tale, Masaba chose to be destiny's child. The daughter of Indian actress Neena Gupta and former West Indies cricketer Viv Richards, Masaba grew up in the lap of Maximum City. "I was impatient, hungry, very keen to prove myself at a very young age, and very sure of myself. I think that's why I decided to launch my own label," she explains.

HER TAKE

"Your identity is beyond the kitchen, the home and managing other people's lives. We are multitaskers by nature and can do anything we set our minds to"

At age 19, when most young women are still figuring out love and life choices, Masaba launched her own fashion label. "I don't think this was really my calling right at the top of my head. I think it found me rather than me finding it," she says. "While I didn't know that I wanted to be an entrepreneur back then, I knew that I wanted to build a brand. Even though my mother let me experiment a little with singing and dancing, she was very clear that I should do something that had longevity attached to it. So, when I finally decided to take her advice, she was very happy."

While her mother funded everything in the beginning, Masaba admits taking decisions like these while still young has a lot to do with having the financial freedom to do so. "Many people don't have the opportunity to try different things or spend money discovering what they're good at because they need to start earning immediately and contribute to their families. I was fortunate that my mother could support me."

In the early years, she believes she may have been taken a little lightly because people assume that famous parents come with accompanying benefits, but, "over time," she says, "people respect consistency. I have continued building this brand consistently for 17 years, and I intend to keep going for as long as I can."

Among what she counts as the milestones in her journey are the Kareena Kapoor Khan bridal campaign in 2023; dressing legendary French footballer Zinedine Zidane ("I had the opportunity to dress him in an Indian sherwani"); the Aditya Birla Group's acquisition of House of Masaba in 2022, which is currently valued at Rs 360 crore and runs 20 retail stores across the country; launching LoveChild by Masaba; acting in *Masaba Masaba* ("It was incredibly fulfilling because I got to make my acting debut exactly the way I wanted to").

Marriage and a baby heading for the terrible twos keep Masaba busy these days, but not enough to forget her first love. "For House of Masaba, I see a lot more luxury and a lot less noise," she says. "We'll be sharper in our product offering and define our identity much more distinctly as we move ahead." ■

— Chumki Bharadwaj

Photograph by **MANDAR DEODHAR**